



God decides to
bring about the
existence of
contingent things

The right hand side of the dilemma might not look too bad at first. We might think, for example, that we can explain God's creation of contingent things in terms of God's deciding to create contingent things.

But this just gives us a new fact:

And this fact must be necessary, or contingent.

If it is necessary, then, again, premise (1) of our initial argument is false.

And if it is contingent, then by the PSR it must have some explanation. But what could this be?



Leibniz's
argument



the
PSR



objections
to the
PSR

The problem for Leibniz's argument is that we can keep asking this question. And this seems to give us just two choices.

Option 1.

We eventually supply a necessary fact as an explanation of the fact that God creates contingent things. But that threatens to make the existence of contingent things necessary, which falsifies premise (1) of Leibniz's argument.

Option 2.

There is an infinite series of contingent facts, each one of which explains the next.









containing thinning



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... we cannot find in any of the individual things, or even in the entire collection and series of things, a sufficient reason for why they exist.

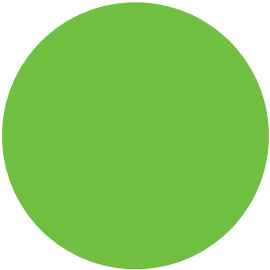
Let us suppose that a book on the elements of geometry has always existed, one copy always made from another. It is obvious that although we can explain a present copy of the book from the previous book from which it was copied, this will never lead us to a complete explanation, no matter how many books back we go, since we can always wonder why there have been such books.

What is true of these books is also true of the different states of the world ... however far back we might go into previous states, we will never find in those states a complete explanation for why there is a world at all, and why it is the way it is.





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Optiion 1.

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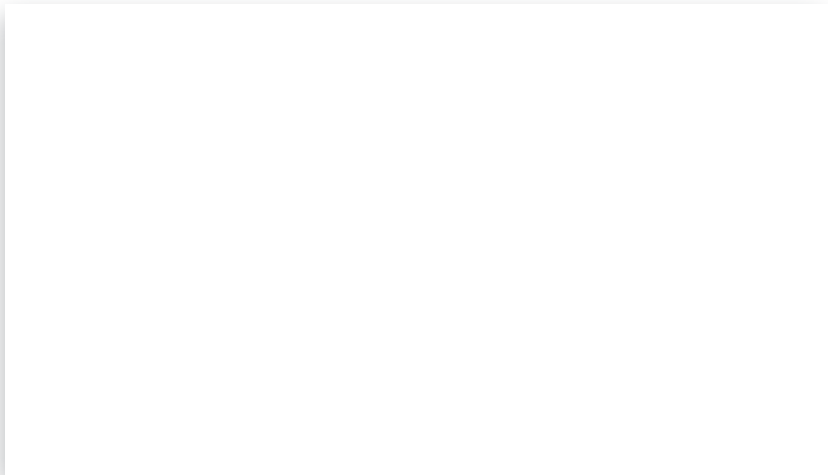
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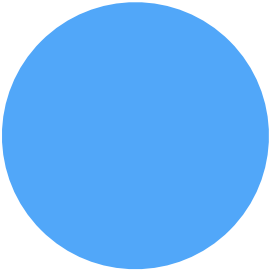
Optiion 2.

of contingent facts, each

one of which explains the

There is a finite series

index.





simply be some event, like the Big Bang, which is not a plausible candidate to

be Good.

cause exists, then God exists: the objection was that the first cause could

Last time we considered an objection to Aquinas' assumption that if a first

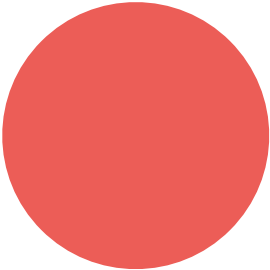


Leibniz's
argument





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objections
to the
PSR



A large, solid yellow circle is centered on a white background. Inside the circle, the text "God decides to bring about the existence of contingent things" is written in a dark gray, serif font. The text is arranged in five lines, centered horizontally within the circle.

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